

Session 13: God's Covenant with Abram

Key Takeaways

- In the narrative logic, faith leads to right standing with God, and doubt leads to covenant. A covenant, though a beautiful expression of God's mercy, is not the ideal.
- Yahweh seals the covenant alone, binding himself to bear the responsibilities of both parties.

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 15:7-21

A

⁷ And he said to him,
"I am Yahweh who brought you out of Ur of the Chaldeans,
to give you this land, to possess it."

⁸ And he said,
"O Lord God, how may I know that I will possess it?"

B

⁹ So he said to him,
a "Bring me a three year old heifer,
b and a three year old female goat,
c and a three year old ram,
and a turtledove,
and a young pigeon."

a ¹⁰ And he brought all these to him
b' and **he halved them** in the middle,
and **he laid each half to meet its neighbor**,
c' but the birds he did not halve.

¹¹ And there came down birds of prey upon the carcasses,
and Avram blew them away.

B'

¹² **And it came about as the sun was going down**,
a **a deep-sleep**
b fell upon Avram;
a' and behold, **terror and great darkness**
b' fell upon him.

13 And God said to Avram,
 “Know for certain that **your seed will be immigrants in a land** that is not theirs,
 and they will be enslaved to them,
 and they will oppress them **four hundred years**.
 14 But also that I myself will judge the nation whom to which they are slaves,
 and afterward they will come out with many possessions.
 15 And as for you, you shall go to your fathers in peace;
 you will be buried at a good old age.
 16 Then in **the fourth generation** they will return here,
 for the iniquity of the Amorite is not complete until this point.”

17 **And it came about as the sun went down**,
 that there was **a deep-darkness**,
 and behold, **an oven smoking**,
 and **a torch of fire**,
 passed **between these pieces**.

18 On that day the Lord made a covenant with Avram, saying,
 “**To your seed I have given this land**, from the river of Egypt as far as the great river, the river
 Euphrates:
 19 the Kenite and the Kenizzite and the Kadmonite
 20 and the Hittite and the Perizzite and the Rephaim
 21 and the Amorite and the Canaanite and the Girgashite and the Jebusite.”

Genesis 15:7-21. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Notice the structural emphasis on the three divine speeches; each one focuses on the divine blessing promises of “seed” and “land.” Unit A has the promise of land for Avram personally, Unit A’ has the promise of his future seed being enslaved in a land not their own, and Unit A” has the combined promise that the seed who leaves and comes back will possess the land promised to Avram.

Also notice how the sacrificial birds play a prominent role in the setting of the apocalypse and the covenant. Each one is described with language that will be activated later on in the design patterns of apocalypse and covenant narratives.

Cutting the Pieces of the Covenant: Genesis 15 and Jeremiah 34

Genesis 15:9-11, 17 Instructor’s Translation

9 So he said to him,
 “Bring me a three year old heifer,
 and a three year old female goat,
 and a three year old ram,

and a turtledove,
and a young pigeon.”

¹⁰ And he brought all these to him
and **he halved them** in the middle,
and **he laid each half to meet its neighbor**, but the birds he did not halve.

¹¹ And there came down birds of prey upon the carcasses, and Avram blew them away.

¹⁷ ... and a torch of fire passed **between these pieces**.

Jeremiah 34:13, 18-20 NASB*

¹³ Thus says the LORD God of Israel, "I cut a covenant with your forefathers in the day that I brought them out of the land of Egypt, from the house of bondage, saying ...

¹⁸ I will give the men who have transgressed my covenant, who have not fulfilled the words of the covenant which they made before me, when they cut the calf in two and passed between its pieces— ¹⁹ the officials of Judah and the officials of Jerusalem, the court officers and the priests and all the people of the land who passed between the pieces of the calf— ²⁰ I will give them into the hand of their enemies and into the hand of those who seek their life. And their dead bodies will be food for the birds of the sky and the beasts of the earth."

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The meaning of this covenant ceremony is elaborated further by Jeremiah. The animal halves represent the consequence of breaking the covenant. Those who walk between the pieces are then obligated to fulfill their covenant obligations. If they don't, their fate will be like these severed animals.

It is supremely important, then, that God does not allow Avram to walk through the pieces. Instead, God incapacitates him, making him pass out on the sidelines, while God alone passes through the pieces. The symbolism has a clear and powerful message: God alone will be responsible for the fulfillment of his promise, and he will carry the consequences of the failure and success of both parties.

The Apocalypse of Avram

God's appearance to Avram is the first time that fire and smoke are associated with the divine presence. This imagery will continue to develop throughout the biblical story and will come to a high point in the appearances of Yahweh on top of Mount Sinai.

Genesis 15:12, 17 Instructor's Translation

¹² And it came about as the sun was going down, a deep-sleep fell upon Avram; and behold, **terror and great darkness** (חשכה / *hashekah*) fell upon him ...

¹⁷ And it came about as the sun went down, that there was a **deep-darkness**, and behold, an **oven smoking** (תנור עשן / *tannur 'ashan*), and a **torch of fire** (לפיד אש / *lappid 'esh*) passed between these pieces.

Exodus 19:16-18 NIV*

¹⁶ On the morning of the third day there was **thunder and lightning**, with a **thick cloud** over the mountain, and a very loud trumpet blast. Everyone in the camp trembled. ¹⁷ Then Moses led the people out of the

camp to meet with God, and they stood at the foot of the mountain.

¹⁸ Mount Sinai was covered with smoke, because the LORD descended on it in **fire** (אֵשׁ / 'esh). The **smoke** (עָשָׁן / 'ashan) billowed up from it **like smoke from a furnace**, and the whole mountain trembled violently.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Exodus 20:18, 21 NIV*

¹⁸ When the people saw the **thunder** and **lightning** (לִפְיֵד / lappid) and heard the trumpet and saw the mountain in **smoke** (עָשָׁן / 'ashen), they trembled with fear. They stayed at a distance ...

²¹ The people remained at a distance, while Moses approached the **thick darkness** where God was.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Deuteronomy 4:11-12 NIV

¹¹ You came near and stood at the foot of the mountain while it **blazed with fire** to the very heavens, with **black clouds and deep darkness**. ¹² Then the LORD spoke to you out of the **fire**. You heard the sound of words but saw no form; there was only a voice.

Psalms 18:9-12 NIV*

⁹ He parted the heavens and came down; dark clouds (עֲרַפֵּל / 'araphel) were under his feet.

¹⁰ He mounted the cherubim and flew; he soared on the wings of the wind.

¹¹ He made darkness (חֹשֶׁךְ / khoshek) his covering, his canopy around him—rain clouds of darkness (חֲשֻׁכָּה / khashekah) in the sky.

¹² Out of the brightness of his presence clouds advanced, with hailstones and coals of fire (גַּחְלֵי אֵשׁ / gakhale 'esh).

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The Cosmic Promised Land

The boundaries of the promised land, which take up the promises of [Genesis 12:7](#) and [13:14-18](#), offer the first rough description of the land promised to Avram.

Genesis 15:18-21 Instructor's Translation

¹⁸ On that day the LORD made a covenant with Avram, saying,

“To your seed I have given this land, from the river of Egypt as far as the great river, the river Euphrates:

¹⁹ the Kenite and the Kenizzite and the Kadmonite

²⁰ and the Hittite and the Perizzite and the Rephaim

²¹ and the Amorite and the Canaanite and the Girgashite and the Jebusite.”

This passage invites us to explore a long-standing puzzle that involves two distinct mapping patterns found in biblical descriptions of the promised land.

Promised Land Mapping Pattern 1

In the first mapping pattern, the promised land is bordered on the west by the Mediterranean Sea and on the east by the Jordan River, with the north-eastern boundary going up into Syria and Lebanon.

Numbers 34:2-12 NIV

² Command the Israelites and say to them: "When you enter Canaan, the land that will be allotted to you as an inheritance is to have these boundaries:

³ Your **southern side** will include some of the Desert of Zin along the border of Edom. Your southern boundary will start in the east from the southern end of the Dead Sea ... and [eventually] join the Wadi of Egypt and end at the Mediterranean Sea.

⁶ Your **western boundary** will be the coast of the Mediterranean Sea. This will be your boundary on the west.

⁷ For your **northern boundary**, run a line from the Mediterranean Sea to Mount Hor

⁸ and from Mount Hor to Lebo Hamath. Then the boundary will go to Zedad,

⁹ continue to Ziphron and end at Hazar Enan. This will be your boundary on the north.

¹⁰ For your **eastern boundary** ... along the slopes east of the Sea of Galilee.

¹² Then the boundary will go down along the Jordan and end at the Dead Sea.

This will be your land, with its boundaries on every side."

Other examples of this boundary pattern: [Joshua 15:1-63](#); [Ezekiel 47](#)



[Openstreetmap.org](https://www.openstreetmap.org).

Promised Land Mapping Pattern 2

Exodus 23:31 NIV

I will establish your borders from the Red Sea to the Mediterranean Sea, and from the desert to the Euphrates River. I will give into your hands the people who live in the land, and you will drive them out before you.

Deuteronomy 11:24 NIV

Every place where you set your foot will be yours: Your territory will extend from the desert to Lebanon, and from the Euphrates River to the Mediterranean Sea.

Joshua 1:4 NIV

Your territory will extend from the desert to Lebanon, and from the great river, the Euphrates—all the Hittite country—to the Mediterranean Sea in the west.

1 Kings 4:20-21 NIV

²⁰ The people of Judah and Israel were as numerous as the sand on the seashore; they ate, they drank and they were happy.

²¹ And Solomon ruled over all the kingdoms from the Euphrates River to the land of the Philistines, as far as the border of Egypt. These countries brought tribute and were Solomon's subjects all his life.

Other examples of this boundary pattern: [Deuteronomy 1:7-8](#); [Genesis 2:10-14](#)



[Openstreetmap.org](https://openstreetmap.org).

These two maps seem to have different symbolic value, so they communicate different things.

Pattern 1 is smaller and more historically realistic to the actual proportions of Israel's territory. The boundaries shrank throughout time, as they lost more and more land to their neighbors. You could call this the "realistic map."

Pattern 2 is much larger and more historically idealistic. For a brief period of Solomon's reign, it seems he had influence over this region, but it quickly ended when he died. This map, however, has symbolic value connected to the garden of Eden, which was itself the source of these two rivers.

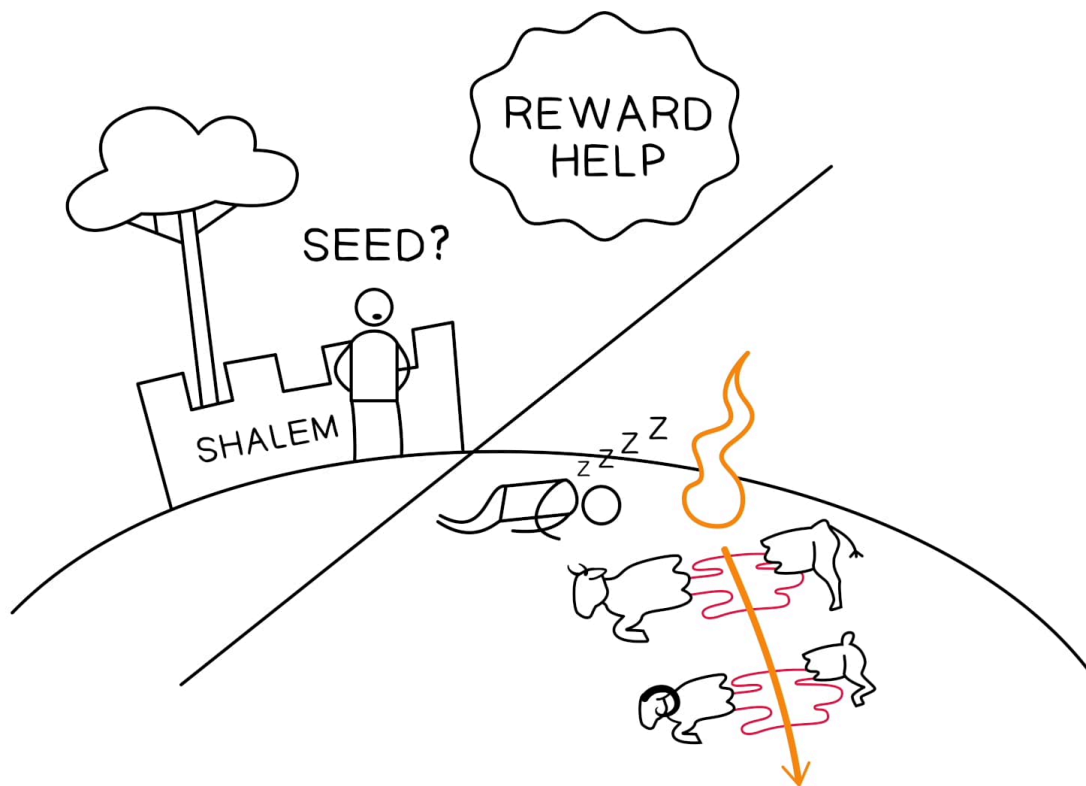
There is also significance in the fact that the two rivers on each side of this description are the life sources of Israel's two greatest imperial enemies in the biblical story: Egypt and Babylon.

"The two maps reflect Israel as conceived in relation to the two great empires that it was engaged by Egypt and Babilonia. The first mapping pattern encompasses the boundaries of province of Canaan under Egyptian rule. In the symbolism of the exodus story, God liberated Israel from slavery in Egypt and then gave them the land of Canaan ... The borders of map 1 are the Egyptian-defined border, rather than a description of Israel's exact borders at any specific moment in its history. The map expresses Israel's resistance to Egyptian rule. The second mapping pattern presents Israel as a power reaching up to the river that sources Babylon. Babylonian propaganda considered all the land west of the Euphrates as conquered

territory. The biblical map turns this around. The land west of the Euphrates is the land of promise for Israel. Thus, both maps represent one way in which Israel resisted the imperial powers, as they symbolically push their enemies back behind the rivers from which they came.”

Parry, Robin (2014). [*The Biblical Cosmos: A Pilgrim's Guide to the Weird and Wonderful World of the Bible*](#). Cascade Books. 67.

Visualizing the Covenant Scene



God's First Covenant With Avram. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Reflection Question

What meaning can we infer from God alone passing between the animals in the covenant scene of Genesis 15:7-21?